relatively isolated groups far from well-traveled routes and in the hinterlands of Khurasani centers.[28]

Given the frugality, if not asceticism, for which the Karramiyya were known, it seems unlikely that a monumental and lavishly decorated *madrasa* complex such as Shah-i Mashhad would conform to their ideological and practical standards.[29] Karrami proselytism was indeed carried out through group activity, and was closely associated with residence in and operation from communal lodgings or *khanaqah*s, which also served as sites of instruction and other charitable work (e.g., feeding and sheltering the poor). But historical authors often used *khanaqah*, *ribat*, and *madrasa* interchangeably: by the twelfth century, these structures were all multi-functional, communal spaces intended principally for instruction, at times including a tomb and/or a mosque or other place for prayer.[30] Moreover, the term *madrasa* did not necessarily imply large-scale construction: the increasing monumentality of *madrasa*s throughout the mid- to late eleventh century has in fact been seen as a development at least partially attributable to the Saljuq push to control Khurasan through patronage of select *madhhab*s.[31] Thus, while textual sources referred to Karrami institutions as *madrasa*s in cities such as Nishapur, it is improbable that these were the towering edifices associated with the orthodox *madhhab*s favored both by the ruling elites and the economically prominent mercantile groups.[32] Ultimately, an exquisitely illuminated Qur'an could command ascetic spiritual fervor *qua* ritual object; its architectural equivalent, however, would surely be perceived as alien to the austerity that characterized Karrami preceptors and their principles, an austerity that continued as one of the few constants over time, distinguishing their *modus vivendi* from that of the other *madhhab*s.[33]

But eliminating a Karrami affiliation for Shah-i Mashhad brings us little closer to definitively ascertaining the *madhhab* – or possibly more than one[34] – housed at the *madrasa*. The complex was designed and built on a monumental scale and, even after much deterioration, retains traces of an exquisite decorative program encompassing admirably executed monumental inscriptions (discussed further below). These characteristics emphatically point to the complex's affiliation with the established legal–theological schools favored in Khurasan, quite possibly the Hanafi and/or the Shafi'i *madhhab*s – the latter proposed by S. Blair.[35] Nevertheless, the orientation of Shah-i Mashhad, along with its extensive and unusual epigraphic program, both lead to more questions than answers, and point to multiple possibilities for the complex's sectarian affiliation.

Shah-i Mashhad has a nearly north–south orientation (Figures 4.2 and 4.3), so that the whole complex deviates counterclockwise from the cardinal directions of true south and west (180° and 270°, respectively) by only a few degrees, possibly due to accommodation of the terrain – though this is unverifiable without on-site study. Since 243.69° would be Shah-i